

Zeke Zalinski

Director of UX / Experience Strategy & Design Systems

Summary

Design executive spanning fine art, brand, e-commerce, agency creative direction, and UX department leadership, who takes an overlooked or undefined UX department and builds it into something with a defined function, internal credibility, and its own process. Presents that same case to leadership and to Customer Success, Sales, and Marketing, so they can speak to intentional, user-centered work directly with customers. Operates at both the executive and pixel level, reading where a company is headed and building the UX architecture and strategy to support that vision.

Highlights

- 8-to-5 team restructuring: defining responsibilities, roles, autonomy, and process for each designer made the department more efficient, allowing a headcount cut of more than a third without losing capability.
- 95% customer adoption: designed and led the phased migration of every application onto the Accelerate, delivering a promise customers had heard "one more year" for years, and giving Sales real proof.
- 20+ products, 6 Scrum teams: grew the Accelerate Design System from a single product's component library into full company-wide adoption.

Skills

- UX org buildout, team mentorship & talent development
- Cross-functional leadership and C-suite partnership: thought leadership, product, customer success, design, back-end, front-end dev, and executive design strategy
- Design systems architecture: scalable guardrails for engineering autonomy
- AI-assisted design workflow integration (Figma Make, Lovable, Claude)
- UX Direction: wireframes, prototypes & specs, plus continuous discovery and research integration
- Post-acquisition UX portfolio alignment

Work Experience

VelocityEHS / Director of User Experience & Design

Jun 2021 – May 2026

Brought in to assess and restructure a UX department at this environmental, health and safety software company, supporting 20+ organically built and acquired SaaS products. After 15 months leading the integration of a newly acquired company's software onto the VelocityEHS design system, was promoted to Director to lead the department.

- Designed the brand and user experience for Vēlo, VelocityEHS's patented AI assistant, then partnered with ML scientists to place it at users' key decision points, becoming the proof behind the company's Ask Vēlo campaign and AI-driven marketing.
- Caught a gap between the navigation experience leadership was promising and what the product actually delivered, then led the fix: Accelerate Navigation, now the company-wide standard.
- Built an in-house WCAG/VPAT accessibility practice, led by a Senior Designer instead of an outside vendor, to meet enterprise and education-sector requirements.
- Led the 2025 Accelerate Design System rebrand: tested the CSS master library's flexibility for color and component changes, then designed and presented three concept directions to product and marketing stakeholders.

Career Pause / Full-time Parent

Feb 2020 – Jun 2021

Stepped back from professional work to manage family full-time during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Maestro Health / Director of Experience Design

Feb 2015 – Feb 2020

Brought in as a 30-person healthcare startup's first and only UX voice, tasked with ownership of the full experience from discovery through delivery.

- Sole UX leader across 12 healthcare applications for five years, owning the full experience in a regulated, data-heavy environment.
- Designed custom applications from the ground up that replaced paper-based HR workflows, solving problems no one had digitized before.
- Built the department's UX process from scratch, starting as sketches and user flows worked out directly with the CTO and Head of Product, then scaling into how R&D defined, designed, and developed every application as the company grew from 30 people into a full insurance platform.

Z Design (Independent) / UX & Design Consultant

Sep 2013 – Mar 2015

- Led UX and design at Rocket Web, translating business and project goals into e-commerce content, design, and UX strategy, while helping shape how the agency branded its own offerings to the market.
- Partnered with 50,000feet's UX Director and Director of Development on several Abbott Labs engagements, and provided project direction and consultation as the agency planned and built its own new website.

Siteworx / Creative Director

Sep 2012 – Sep 2013

One of four founding directors of Siteworx's first remote office, the only location to launch with leadership across all four pillars: sales, development, engagement, and design.

- Led the creative department through the full client lifecycle: discovery and stakeholder interviews, concept, production, and development handoff.
- Concepted and presented directly for clients like Grant Thornton and American College of Surgeons, with the ACS design direction selected and winning the contract.
- Operated as a full business partner alongside sales, development, and engagement leads: pitches, SOW approvals, resource planning, and account strategy.

Other Experiences / E-commerce Art Direction, Creative Direction**Lyons Consulting Group** / Associate Creative Director

Led e-commerce design work on Magento and Demandware CMS platforms, and led the agency's own rebrand as primary client-facing creative lead.

Gorilla / Senior Design Lead

E-commerce and IA lead during the agency's Magento Partner of the Year win; IMCA Award for Axient.net.

Education

Illinois State University / Bachelor of Fine Arts, Graphic Design